

Receiving the Mind of Christ

Open to Romans 8. We will back up to verse 11 and take it through adoption again, though we will do little more than read it.

In this study, we have been graduating from Romans 7 to Romans 8 and finding out Paul's terminology: "in the flesh" versus "in the Spirit." Between these two chapters, Paul walked out the difference between the Old Covenant and the covenant that brought our sonship. With the precision of a lawyer, he argued covenant versus sonship.

Romans 7 begins:

"I speak to them that know the law."

He was teaching a very large Jewish community. They were beginning to have trouble with Gentiles, the swine-eating Gentiles, receiving the same inheritance they had received through the promise made to Abraham and his Seed.

Eventually, some of them settled on this: a man could become Abraham's seed through Christ, but to be perfect he had to go on and keep the law. These Judaizers went to Antioch, and then they were cleaning up in Galatia. Paul, the apostle born out of due season, came on the scene just in time to give the Church her foundation and get her out from under the law and legalism, back under grace.

Romans 7 describes the Jew who received the law as a spiritually dead man and could not keep it. Paul uses first person language:

"When I was in the flesh..."

That is the terminology. Then Romans 8 opens:

"Who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit."

He is not talking about a born-again believer having a bad day. He is talking about an unregenerated Jew with the sin nature who received the law and could not keep it.

When Paul says, "When I was in the flesh," he says the motions of sin, sin on the move, were by the law. When he received the commandment, "Thou shalt not covet," the motions of sin worked in his members to bring forth fruit unto death. The law did not cause him to become spiritually dead; it brought forth fruit unto the death he had already received from the first man Adam.

That is why he described the dilemma:

"The good that I would, I do not:
but the evil which I would not, that I do."

Then he cried:

"Who shall deliver me from the body of this death?"

And he answered his own question:

"I thank God through Jesus Christ our Lord."

Then he began the covenant that brought our sonship:

"There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus,
who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit."

There are no more condemning sentences under the judicial system of the law to be carried out in us. We are in Christ Jesus, and we walk after the regenerated, born-again human spirit.

Romans 8 explains how this happened:

"For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus
hath made me free from the law of sin and death."

What is the Spirit of life? It is the regenerated, born-again human spirit. The law of that Spirit of life in Christ Jesus brought Him from death to life, and when you were quickened together with Him, that same law brought you from death to life.

What is the law of sin and death? It is the law that says an unregenerated nature can produce nothing but sin and death. To the Jew, it said, "When you would do good, evil is present with you."

The law was their schoolmaster. It schooled them thoroughly in the fact that they had a nature that could not inherit heaven and could not keep God's commandments. It prepared the way for God to lay both Jew and Gentile upon one Man, Christ Jesus.

Romans 8 then argues our freedom by showing the power of the rebirth. It was the rebirth itself that set us free from the dominion of sin. Paul has not yet introduced the Holy Spirit distinctly until he says:

"The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit,
that we are the children of God."

Then he mentions Him again in verse 26:

"Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities."

He would not have said "also" if something else were not already helping them. The new nature set us free from sin. The Holy Spirit came to help that freedom.

This makes Jesus' words to the Samaritan woman very interesting:

"The hour cometh, and now is,
when the true worshippers shall worship the Father in spirit and in truth."

If that hour had now come, then no one before that time had worshiped in spirit and in truth, except possibly Adam before the fall. Our kind of worship is exclusive to the New Testament.

Be careful that you do not get into that old warlike worship that belonged to a spiritually dead man. Did Old Testament saints worship God? Certainly. If an eight- or nine-foot giant is about to beat the living daylights out of you, and you turn around with your sword and find yourself even with his belt buckle, you will worship. You will cry, "Help me, O God!" God would say, "Kill an animal. Let the blood be a type, and I will come." Then He would part the Red Sea, drive nations out, and they would worship the God who could do that.

But how well could they know Him?

Jesus was the first man born spiritually alive in four thousand years who could receive the Spirit without measure. John had the Holy Spirit come into his life in the womb for the purpose and plan of God, as the Spirit came upon Old Testament saints. But Jesus received the Spirit without measure.

When you and I were born again, receiving the same life He has, we began receiving the Spirit. God had waited four thousand years for this. Jesus told the Samaritan woman, in effect, "The Father has been seeking this kind of worship. This hour has finally come."

Now we can worship Him in spirit and in truth because we have received the adoption of sons. His nature is in us. Truth is on the inside of us. I can worship Him out of that nature. He is my Father. I am His son. We are in holy communion.

Old Testament saints saw this from afar off, but their relationship with God was not like yours, and neither was their worship.

I am having the best fun being a son of God. He calls me a child. His Spirit bears witness with our spirit that we are the children of God.

Soon the adoption process will be complete. That part of it is not something we complete by our own effort. It happens when this body gives way to a glorified body. Then the adoption is made complete, and He calls us manifested sons of God.

Spirit, soul, and body will no longer possess a body given by the first man Adam. We will have one given by the last Adam, Jesus.

Someone may ask, "How do you feel about that?"

I hasten toward it. With the confidence I have in Him now as His son, I am going to tear up a lot of hell while I am here.

The most difficult verse we passed was Romans 8:11:

"But if the Spirit of him that raised up Jesus from the dead dwell in you,
he that raised up Christ from the dead
shall also quicken your mortal bodies
by his Spirit that dwelleth in you."

All of us in Pentecostal holiness circles preached that as the Holy Spirit. But Paul says, "the Spirit of Him." As the Father had life in Himself, He gave to the Son to have life in Himself. Jesus was born spiritually alive, died, and then God quickened His human spirit back to life.

That is the spirit Paul is talking about. If the Spirit of Him that raised Jesus from the dead dwells in you, then He that raised Christ from the dead will also quicken, or supply life to, your mortal body, so it is free and does not have to sin.

Because you now have a quickened human spirit that went from death to life with Christ, Paul can say boldly:

"Therefore, brethren,
we are debtors,
not to the flesh,
to live after the flesh."

That death nature has been canceled, and so has your debt to serve sin.

Romans 8:13 says:

"For if ye live after the flesh, ye shall die:
but if ye through the Spirit do mortify the deeds of the body,
ye shall live."

Again, "flesh" here is not a bad hair day. It is not waking up, finally finding the mirror, and saying, "I guess I was just in the flesh." According to positional truth, "in the flesh" means that the motions of sin, which were by the law, worked in the members to bring forth fruit unto spiritual death.

If you live after the flesh, you die in your sins. But if through the regenerated, born-again spirit you mortify the deeds of the body, you live.

Verse 11 says the new nature quickens the mortal body; verse 13 says through that spirit you mortify the deeds of the body. One brings life, and the other kills. Which is it? Both. The new nature supplies life to the body, and that life brings the wrong deeds of the flesh to a standstill.

Under the law, God gave the Jew the commandment, "Thou shalt not covet." His mind turned inward for strength and found an unregenerated nature of sin. That nature warred against his mind and brought him into captivity.

Now that you are born again, when God says, "Thou shalt not covet," your mind turns inward and runs into a nature that has been set free. That nature supplies life and quickens your mortal body so you do not have to sin.

As yet, Paul still has not even mentioned the Holy Spirit. If the Holy Spirit could have set men free without the help of the new nature, He would have set all the Old Testament saints free in their nature. He could not. Your new nature sets you free. The Holy Spirit has come to enforce that freedom.

I can say, "I do not want to sin." The devil says, "I am overpowering you." If I cannot handle him, I have Someone who can. I will tell him to leave one more time, and if he does not, the Lord can send as many legions as necessary. My advice to the devil is simple: back off.

I was trying to leave one of the meetings in Sao Paulo and wait for a ride home. A woman grabbed me as I came through the door and said, "I am a gypsy, and I am tormented. Can you pray for me?"

I said, "Yes."

I laid my hand on her, and her throat swelled right in front of my eyes. She started choking. I said, "Come out of her." She began growling while people were walking around us. I said, "Come out." She stumbled, fell into a chair, and got free.

I like to leave a service and cast the devil out on the way out. I like to do that. I like to make a mess on the streets in India: just start walking down the street, getting people healed, and after a while you have a Book of Acts crowd following you around to watch the miracles.

Romans 8:14 says:

"For as many as are led by the Spirit of God,
they are the sons of God."

Again, this is the born-again human spirit, not the first distinct introduction of the Holy Spirit. Look back at Romans 8:5:

"For they that are after the flesh do mind the things of the flesh;
but they that are after the Spirit the things of the Spirit."

Those who are after the flesh have their thought systems dominated by the unregenerated nature. The motions of sin declare war against their mind and bring it into captivity.

Those who are after the regenerated, born-again spirit have a mind free to follow after the works and acts of righteousness. As many as are able to be led by the Spirit of that new nature are sons of God. They are free to obey.

Romans 8:6-7 says:

"For to be carnally minded is death;
but to be spiritually minded is life and peace.
Because the carnal mind is enmity against God:
for it is not subject to the law of God,
neither indeed can be."

To be carnally minded is to have the mind under the ascendancy of the unregenerated spirit. To be spiritually minded is to have the mind under the ascendancy of the new nature, which results in life and peace. When I would do good now, peace is present with me. My mind is under a new nature that produces righteous acts with no condemnation, no anchors, and no power strong enough to stop me.

Paul is still arguing his case when he comes to adoption:

"For ye have not received the spirit of bondage again to fear;
but ye have received the Spirit of adoption,
whereby we cry, Abba, Father."

The spirit of bondage again to fear was especially addressed to the Jew. As spiritually dead men, they were given commandments they could not keep, and generation after generation that produced bondage again to fear. The law set the motions of sin into operation.

But we have received the spirit of adoption. This should be understood as the born-again human spirit, adopted from the family of the first man Adam into the family of the last Adam. Now we can cry, "Abba, Father."

Verse 16 says:

"The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit,
that we are the children of God."

This is the first clear mention of the Holy Spirit in the chapter. You could erect a little monument there, because many religious ideas die at that verse. His Spirit bears witness with my spirit that I am His son. I do not have the spirit of bondage again to fear.

First Corinthians calls the Gentile version "the spirit of the world." The Gentile did not have the law, so he did not have that repeated bondage again to fear under the commandments. He simply had the spirit of the world. But now we have the spirit which is of God, and we can know the things freely given to us by God.

The first mention of the Holy Spirit in Romans 8 is verse 16. The second is verse 26:

"Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities."

Now we know unequivocally that the new nature first set us free. The Holy Spirit bears witness to that freedom, and then Paul introduces the ministry of the Holy Spirit.

Why does he say "also"? Because something else already helps: the new nature that quickens the mortal body and supplies power against unrighteous acts. When we receive a glorified body, the adoption process will be complete. Meanwhile, I do not mind being left here to carry on the ministry of reconciliation. The more I find out what I am capable of in Him, the more glad I am to be here.

The infirmities are the innumerable weaknesses and limitations imposed on the soul by the flesh. They include the inability to produce righteous results because of those limitations, and the inability to understand the righteousness we have been made.

So the help the Holy Spirit brings is the manifestation of the understanding of the mind of Christ inside us. Once that begins, victory enters. Off with unrighteous works; on with the revelation and the walk of the mind of Christ in every area of life.

Romans 8:26-27 says:

"For we know not what we should pray for as we ought:
but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us
with groanings which cannot be uttered.
And he that searcheth the hearts
knoweth what is the mind of the Spirit,
because he maketh intercession for the saints
according to the will of God."

The groanings cannot be uttered in natural speech because their origin is supernatural. Here enters the mind of Christ into a righteous spirit.

He that searches the hearts is the Holy Spirit. He searches the righteous, childlike, born-again spirit inside you and knows the mind of the Spirit. That enables Him to make intercession for the saints according to the will of God.

Then verse 28 follows:

"And we know that all things work together for good
to them that love God,
to them who are the called according to his purpose."

If the mind of Christ is working the purpose and plan of God in you, then all things begin to work together for good. When God is praying for you and God is answering the prayer, you are going to get results.

The spirit of man is the candle of the Lord. It is the part of you God uses to enable you to search God. God does not need to search Himself. The Holy Spirit enables you to search the deep things of God because you are no longer spiritually dead.

Because of an aggressive praying-in-tongues prayer life, I can know that all things are going to work together for my good. I love God, and I am praying the mind of Christ. My life is going to come into line according to His purpose.

Can you imagine parents disciplining children for praying in tongues too much, or disciplining teachers for telling them to pray in tongues? The Holy Spirit is carrying the mind of Christ into the born-again spirit.

My new nature set me free from sin. The Holy Spirit also helps my weaknesses. He brings the power of God, the mind of Christ, and the supernatural language that carries the mind of Christ.

When you were born again and came into the kingdom of God, your spirit was translated out of darkness into light. You did not come in knowing everything, but you came in with a nature that could be taught.

When you were baptized in the Spirit, you received the Teacher. Yet the knowledge within Him is not automatically within you. Like any teacher-student relationship, what is in Him must be transferred to you.

That is why some preachers can have the Holy Spirit and speak with tongues, yet still say foolish things. The Holy Spirit is unable to be their Teacher when He is locked up and not allowed to teach.

The perfect system of teaching is this: the Holy Spirit, carrying the mind of Christ, illuminates my spirit. That is where I understand God. My spirit then illuminates my mind. That is where I communicate God.

If the Holy Spirit is locked up, as He is in many preachers, then there are a million divisions. We cannot agree on the trunk, the limbs, or the leaves. One says healing is for today; another says it is not. Paul said, "Are ye not carnal?" One says, "I am of Paul," and another, "I am of Apollos." Who are we but men who planted and watered? If the Spirit is not giving the increase, men build on the foundation with material that will be burned.

If the Holy Spirit is not your Teacher, you are at the mercy of your intellect. You discern Scripture according to your own gospel and usually according to the people who taught you your doctrine. That is where false doctrine comes from: translating the Word wrong.

If you want an inoculation against ignorance, if you want the Holy Spirit to help those infirmities, you need the understanding of the mind of Christ released in you.

Go to 1 Corinthians 2. Paul says to the Corinthians in five verses what he explained in Romans 8 in much more detail to the Jews.

First Corinthians 2:12 says:

"Now we have received,
not the spirit of the world,
but the spirit which is of God;
that we might know the things
that are freely given to us of God."

Romans 8 calls the Jewish condition the spirit of bondage again to fear. First Corinthians calls the Gentile condition the spirit of the world. But now we have received the spirit which is of God, the born-again spirit that came from God, so we might know the things freely given to us in the adoption of sons.

Verse 13 says:

"Which things also we speak,
not in the words which man's wisdom teacheth,
but which the Holy Ghost teacheth;
comparing spiritual things with spiritual."

The Holy Spirit teaches through the mind of Christ, comparing spiritual heavenly things that came from the mind of Christ with the spiritual new nature you received when you were born again.

Verse 14 says:

"But the natural man receiveth not the things of the Spirit of God:
for they are foolishness unto him:
neither can he know them,
because they are spiritually discerned."

The natural man cannot receive them because they are spiritually discerned through the born-again spirit.

Then Paul says:

"But he that is spiritual judgeth all things,
yet he himself is judged of no man.
For who hath known the mind of the Lord,
that he may instruct him?
But we have the mind of Christ."

That is Romans 8:27 again. He that searches the heart knows the mind of the Spirit, the mind of Christ, and makes intercession for you according to the will of God. Then we know all things work together for good to those who love God and are called according to His purpose.

He that searches the heart will straighten your doctrine out. He will straighten your flesh out. He will work your personal life into the overall purpose of God, which is His plan for your life.

That is the entrance of help for your infirmities.

Hello, Holy Spirit.